

Introduction

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 Nf3 0-0 6 Be2 (Diagram 1)

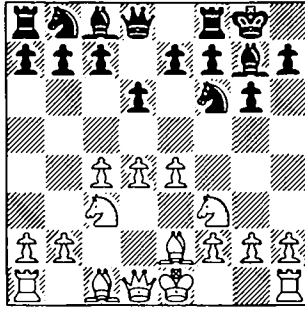


Diagram 1
The Classical Variation

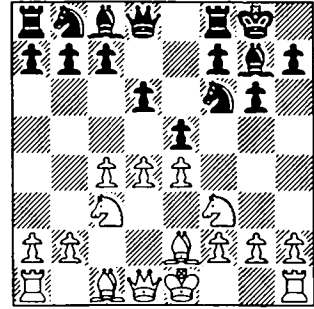


Diagram 2
Black stakes a claim

In The Classical Variation White just concentrates on developing his pieces to sensible squares. 6 Be2 makes more sense than 6 Bd3 as the latter interferes with the protection of the weakest point in the white camp, the d4-square.



NOTE: The d4-square is slightly weak because having played e4 and c4 this square can no longer be protected by pawns.

In many variations of the King's Indian Black will form a plan whose aim is to occupy or control this square. Although the d4-square is weak, or potentially weak, that does not mean that White has made a mistake playing the moves e4 and c4 as they have given him a powerful centre and a space advantage. Chess is all about give and take.

This is by far the most important variation in the King's Indian. That is why it takes up four of the ten chapters in this book.

6...e5! (Diagram 2)

This is an important move. Black stakes his claim in the centre. At first sight it may appear that White can just win a pawn but you can read all about this in the Exchange Variation below. The alternatives deserve a quick mention.

- 1) 6...Nbd7 is played sometimes by those who fear the exchange of queens. It is however a lot less flexible and after 7 0-0 c5 we have transposed to Chapter 2.
- 2) 6...Na6 is playable, again transposing to Chapter 2 after 7 0-0 c5.
- 3) 6...c5 is an alternative strike in the centre but Black will have to be willing to play a Benoni after 7 d5 or a Sicilian after 7 0-0 cxd4 8 Nxd4. Very few players play the King's Indian in order to play 6...c5.

4) 6...Bg4 is a solid line which aims to exchange the bishop for the knight on f3. The idea of this is to slacken White's control of d4. Again it is not really in the style of the King's Indian. A real King's Indian player will preciously guard his light-squared bishop until he can sacrifice it on h3.

After 6...e5 White usually plays 7 0-0 and this is the subject of the next three chapters. This chapter deals with the alternatives.

White Plays 7 dxe5

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 Nf3 0-0 6 Be2 e5 7 dxe5 dxe5 8 Qxd8 Rxd8 (Diagram 3)

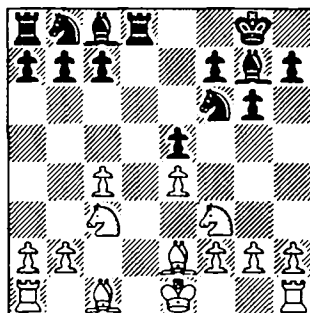


Diagram 3

Not the most adventurous line

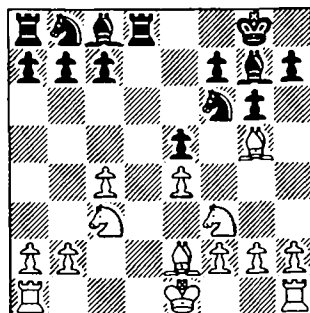


Diagram 4

How should Black deal with the pin?

I shall start this book with the Exchange Variation of the King's Indian. That is because there are a lot of players who say, 'Oh, I would really like to play the King's Indian, but can't they just exchange queens and get a really boring endgame? I'd better stick with the Queen's Gambit Declined.' Well, stick with the Queen's Gambit if you want but there is no reason to be afraid off this endgame. It's White who has to play accurately to hold the balance and it's not so boring if you know what you are doing.

Anyway, here is my view on this exchange variation which I reproduce from another book I wrote on the King's Indian some years ago (*Beating the Anti-King's Indians*, Batsford 1996).

'Practitioners of the Exchange Variation can be divided into three categories. Firstly, there are the endgame lovers who play this system with the intention of grinding you down in a long boring endgame. These people deserve some respect, although our main feeling towards them should be one of sympathy for having such a feeble system against the King's Indian. The second category are the psychologists. These are the tricky characters who select this variation be-

cause they feel that it is the most unpleasant for you to play against, especially if you are noted as a tactical player. The third, and in my experience by far the most numerous category are wimps. They select this variation with the idea of killing the game and achieving an easy draw. On no account should they be given one until every last possibility has been exhausted. Perhaps they will achieve their objective, if they play extremely well, but they should at least be made to suffer.'

As you can imagine, I don't think too highly of this variation. My views have not changed at all. Let's have a look at some more moves:

9 Bg5 (Diagram 4)

White now threatens 10 Nd5.

Exercise 1: You may have spotted 9 Nxe5?. How does Black respond?

9...Re8

9...c6 is a modern line which can lead to sharp play but can also fizzle out easily. 9...Rf8 is also a good move but we are going to concentrate on the reliable variation that was played by Bobby Fischer.

10 Nd5

10 0-0-0 is played much less often but it is not inferior to 10 Nd5. It usually leads to a lengthy manoeuvring game. One possibility for Black is to play 10...Na6 while another typical example is 10...h6 11 Be3 c6 12 Ne1 Be6 13 Nc2 Bf8 14 f3 a6!? 15 Rd2 b5 16 b3 Nbd7 17 Rhd1 Rec8 with an edge for Black, Ludden-Nijboer, Amsterdam 1997.

10...Nxd5 11 cxd5 c6!

Black doesn't want to be left with a weak pawn on an open file.

12 Bc4

After 12 d6?! The pawn would be isolated in the enemy camp.

12...cxd5 13 Bxd5 Nd7!

13...Nc6 or 13...Na6 have also been played but against these moves White does have the chance of a nagging edge.

The position after 13...Nd7 is covered in Games 1 and 2.

Theoretical?

It's not very theoretical – a small slip is not going to cost you the game – but if Black wants to punish the wimps then he should know his system well. By the way, contrary to the normal practice in this book, I'm just covering this variation from the Black view point. White should not play chess like this.

Statistics

All the statistics given in this book are taken from MegaBase 2002, a collection of over 2 million games from international tournaments compiled by ChessBase.

After 7 dxe5 White has scored 49% in just over 3000 games. Not very

impressive when you could consider that on average White scores 54%. A very high 53% of games have finished in draws and many of those have finished around move 10. This variation is, evidently, often the choice of those who have agreed to a day off.

Illustrative Games

Game 1

□ Salgado ■ Gallagher

L'Hospitalet 1992

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 Nf3 0-0 6 Bc2 e5 7 dxe5 dxe5 8 Qxd8 Rxd8 9 Bg5 Re8 10 Nd5 Nxd5 11 cxd5 c6! 12 Bc4 cxd5 13 Bxd5 Nd7! (Diagram 5)

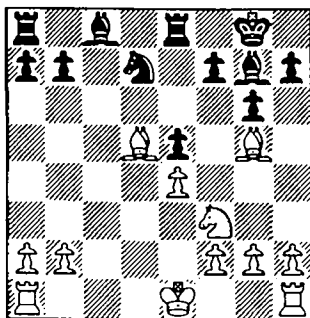


Diagram 5

Black's most accurate deployment

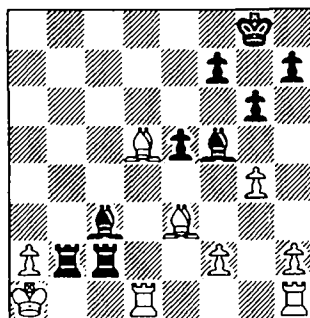


Diagram 6

White will be mated

Black now threatens to gain the bishop pair by 14...Nf6.



NOTE: Bishops work well in tandem and, assuming the position is not totally blocked, it is usually a slight advantage to have two bishops against bishop and knight or two knights.

14 Nd2!

The only way to maintain equality. By defending his e-pawn White renders the ...Nf6 idea harmless. A mistake that White plays quite often is 14 Rc1?!. What could be more natural than to put the rook on an open file? The problem is that after 14...h6 15 Bc3 (15 Bh4 g5 16 Bg3 Nf6 is also good for Black) 15...Nf6 White would be in trouble if he allowed ...Nxd5. That means he has to go in for 16 Bb3 Nxe4 17 Rc7 Be6 18 Bxe6 Rxe6 19 Rxb7 Ra6 20 a3 Nd6! when Black has an edge because he has a mobile central pawn majority and White has still not completed his development. This position was reached in Teschner-Fischer, Stockholm IZ 1962. The young Bobby failed to win but other players have since registered the full point in this ending.

14...Nc5 15 Nc4?!

A slight mistake as it allows Black some tricks based on ...Nxe4, while the knight may also get booted by ...b7-b5 at some point.

Best is 15 0-0-0! and after 15...Ne6! (not 15...Nd3+ 16 Kb1 Nxf2 17 Rdf1! and wins) 16 Be3 Nf4 17 Bxf4 exf4 both 18 Kb1 Be6! 19 Bxe6 Rxe6 20 f3 f5! and 18 f3 Be6 19 Nb3 Bxd5 20 Rxd5 f5! lead to equality. Note how in both cases Black plays ...f7-f5 to activate his rooks.

15...Bf8

This keeps the knight out of d6 and also transfers the bishop to a more active post. There is not much life on the long diagonal.

16 0-0-0

On the last move castling queenside was best. Now it is rather risky. The alternative 16 0-0 can be seen in the next game.

16...Be6 17 Kb1 Rac8

17...Nxe4 18 Bxe4 Rxc4 19 Bxb7 Rab8 is fine for Black but I wanted more. I saw a sneaky way to improve this line.

18 Be3?

Thank you very much. White falls for the trap. He should have played 18 Rhe1 when 18...Bxd5 19 exd5 should be slightly better for Black as White's d-pawn is more likely to turn out weak than strong.

18...Nxe4! 19 Bxe4 Rxc4 20 Bxb7 Rb8 21 Bd5 Bf5+ 22 Ka1 Rc2

Now White suddenly realised that the intended 23 Bb3 fails to 23...Rxb3! 24 axb3 Rc6! and there is no way to stop Ra6 mate. The only chance to resist was 23 Rb1 (although Black is winning after 23...Bc5 24 Bxc5 Rxc5 25 Rbd1 Rc2) but White just picked up his other bishop and played...

23 Bxa7? Rbxb2 24 Be3 Bb4 25 g4 Bc3! (Diagram 6) White resigns

Now that's what I like to do to people who exchange queens in the King's Indian.

Game 2

□ Acebal ■ Gallagher

Candas 1992

1 d4 Nf6 2 c4 g6 3 Nc3 Bg7 4 e4 d6 5 Nf3 0-0 6 Be2 e5 7 dxe5 dxe5 8 Qxd8 Rxd8 9 Bg5 Re8 10 Nd5 Nxd5 11 cxd5 c6 12 Bc4 cxd5 13 Bxd5 Nd7! 14 Nd2! Nc5 15 Nc4 Bf8 16 0-0 Be6 17 Bxe6 Rxc6! (Diagram 7)

At first glance one could dismiss this position as dead drawn, but a closer inspection will reveal a sizeable initiative for Black. His rooks are more active, White's bishop is offside on g5 and the knight on c4 will soon be hit by ...b7-b5.

18 f3 b5 19 Ne3 h6 20 Bh4 Nd3 21 Nd5 Rc8 22 b3 Rc2 23 Rfd1 Nb4! 24 Nxb4 Bxb4 25 Bf2 a6! 26 a3 Bd2!